

SUCCESS GOD'S WAY

* POWER POINT SLIDES

** INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: Genesis 37:3-12 (CEV) *“Now Israel loved Joseph more than all his children, because he was the son of his old age. Also he made him a tunic of many colors. ⁴But when his brothers saw that their father loved him more than all his brothers, they hated him and could not speak peaceably to him. ⁵Now Joseph had a dream, and he told it to his brothers; and they hated him even more. ⁶So he said to them, “Please hear this dream which I have dreamed: ⁷“There we were, binding sheaves in the field. Then behold, my sheaf arose and also stood upright; and indeed your sheaves stood all around and bowed down to my sheaf.” ⁸And his brothers said to him, “Shall you indeed reign over us? Or shall you indeed have dominion over us?” So they hated him even more for his dreams and for his words. ⁹Then he dreamed still another dream and told it to his brothers, and said, “Look, I have dreamed another dream. And this time, the sun, the moon, and the eleven stars bowed down to me.” ¹⁰So he told it to his father and his brothers; and his father rebuked him and said to him, “What is this dream that you have dreamed? Shall your mother and I and your brothers indeed come to bow down to the earth before you?” ¹¹And his brothers envied him, but his father kept the matter in mind.”*

INTRO: Everyone I know who made it big in this world has had moments of disaster and reversals in their lives which seemed too great to negotiate. Think of this:

- In 1860, a thirty-eight year old man was working as a handyman for his father, a leather merchant. He kept books, drove wagons, and sold animal hides for a salary of \$66 a month. Prior to this menial job the man had failed as a soldier, a farmer, and a real estate agent. Most of the people who knew him had written him off as a failure. Eight years later he was President of the United States. The man was Ulysses S. Grant.
- At 22, a young man failed in business. When he was 23, he ran for the legislature and lost. When he was 24, he failed in business again. The following year he was elected to the legislature. When he was 26, his sweetheart died. At the age of 27, he had a nervous breakdown. When he was 29, he was defeated for the post of Speaker of the House in the State Legislature. When he was 31, he was defeated as Elector. When he was 34, he ran for Congress and lost. At the age of 37, he ran for Congress and finally won. Two years later, he ran again and lost his seat in Congress. At the age of 46, he ran for the U.S. Senate and lost. The following year he ran for Vice President and lost that, too. He ran for the Senate again and again lost. Finally, at the age of 51, he was elected President of the United States. Who was

this perpetual loser? It was none other than Abraham Lincoln.

- This person forgot to put a reverse gear in the first car he manufactured and went broke five times. Then in 1957, he bragged about the car of the decade. It was the Edsel, infamous for doors that wouldn't close, a hood that wouldn't open, paint that peeled, a horn that stuck, and a reputation that made it impossible to resell. Henry Ford's future track record contains more successes than failures.
- A young man was cut as a sophomore from his high-school basketball team in Wilmington, N.C. He said, *"The day the cut list was going up, a friend and I went to the gym to look together. If your name was on the list, you made the team. My friends name was there, and mine wasn't. I went through the day numb. After school, I hurried home, closed the door to my room and cried so hard. It was all I wanted--to play on that team."* But that was not the end of the road for Michael Jordan!

Theodore Roosevelt said, *"In any moment of decision the best thing you can do is the right thing, the next best thing is the wrong thing, and the worst thing you can do is nothing. After all, if we do the wrong thing, at least we can learn."*

The life of Joseph spanned: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- One-hundred ten years
- Fourteen chapters

- Four-hundred fifty-nine verses

Little else is given so much screen play as the life of Joseph. The reason Joseph is given so much attention is because he is a type of Christ and is a great case study because he excelled in spite of unbelievable adversity. When we take a close look at his life, he faced the same hurdles all of us face before we can become all God has intended us to be. Ronald Reagan said, *"You and I have a rendezvous with destiny."*

I. DESTINY DISCOVERY

Joseph was the son of Jacob and Rachael. For his parents he was the child who was born late in life and as a result, he no doubt received some special treatment which caused his siblings to develop a strong dislike for him.

Parental partiality always leads to dysfunction within the family unit. The world hates us because of the favor of God upon our lives. [Psalm 102:13](#) (NKJV) ***"You will arise and have mercy on Zion; (In the NT, Zion represents the Church) For the time to favor her, Yes, the set time, has come."*** [Psalm 5:12](#) (NIV) ***"For surely, O LORD, you bless the righteous; you surround them with your favor as with a shield."*** [Psalm 65:11](#) (NKJV) ***"You crown the year with Your goodness, And Your paths drip with abundance."***

When others begin to see the blessings of the Lord upon our lives, they tend to be jealous rather than rejoice with us. We must make sure that when we witness one of our brothers or sisters being blessed we

rejoice with them rather than become jealous of them. We must also learn to give God the credit for all our accomplishments.

Joseph began to dream dreams of exaltation: **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

- He and his brothers binding sheaves in the field, the sheaves of the entire family came and bowed down to Joseph's sheaves.
- The sun, moon, and the stars bow down to Joseph.

According to the Scripture, when Joseph shared his dreams with his brothers, ***"They hated him even more."***

Joseph believed in his destiny and dreamed of how it would come to pass. Orison Swett Marden said, *"The Creator has not given you a longing to do what you have no ability to do."*

If we dream about our destiny and share our dreams with others, oftentimes it will not go over well. We must be careful who we share our dreams with. Not everyone will be thrilled with our dreams. Jack Welch said, *"Control your destiny or somebody else will."*

Joseph was called ***"The Dreamer"*** by his brothers. I am sure he was called a lot of other things but we cannot discuss the possibilities here today! (Church member who attempted to insult me by saying he *"Would have voted for my successor but he was afraid*

I would use him as a puppet to pastor two churches, one in Houston and one in Malvern Arkansas.” I responded by saying, “This may be the greatest compliment I have ever been given as I did not think he believed I could pastor one church and now I discover he thinks I can pastor two churches!”)

God has given me some dreams which I have never shared with anyone but my wife.

Joseph’s dreams came as a result of being in the presence of God. *Dreams born in the presence of God always come to pass, but they are often slow in the developmental stage.* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** I have some good advice for Godly dreamers: patience, patience, patience!

The discovery of his destiny caused many problems to surface in Joseph’s life. His brothers conspired to kill him! His brother Reuben intervened and convinced the remainder of the brotherly mob to throw Joseph in a pit, thinking he would come back at a later time and raise Joseph up out of the pit. Before Reuben could retrieve him, some Midianite merchantmen found Joseph and sold him to the Ishmeelites for twenty pieces of silver. *Mark Twain said, “Keep away from people who try to belittle your ambitions. Small people always do that, but the really great, make you feel that you, too, can become great.”* **(LEAVE UP UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

I would like to sound a warning to all those who dare to dream the dreams of God; beware, the enemy will

do everything in his power to sidetrack you and keep you from fulfilling your destiny! He will even stoop to using your friends and family against you! Matthew 10:36 (KJV) ***"A man's foes shall be they of his own household."***

Destiny discovery can be: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Exciting
- Enlightening
- Exhilarating
- Enlivening
- Energizing

At the same time destiny discovery can be: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Daunting
- Discouraging
- Dispiriting
- Disappointing
- Disheartening

The discovery of a destiny can often bring with it exhilarating highs and depressing lows. Through it all, the roller coaster ride of destiny discovery settles the issue in the heart of the individual. No matter whether we are on a high or fighting our way through a low place, if God gave us the dream we will ascend to the summit of our destiny and lay claim to the prize at the end of the race. The winning prize is to those who are faithful and persistent. [Ecclesiastes](#)

9:11 (NKJV) *“The race is not to the swift, Nor the battle to the strong, Nor bread to the wise, Nor riches to men of understanding, Nor favor to men of skill; But time and chance happen to them all.”* Matthew 24:13 (NKJV) *“He that shall endure unto the end, the same shall be saved.”*

Joseph did not allow the opposition of his brothers to hinder him or to make him bitter. He knew what God said would come to pass, if he remained faithful until faith became sight. He chose not to fight with his brothers but he certainly did not allow their negativity to eclipse his dream. Anthony Robbins said, *“It is in your moments of decision that your destiny is shaped.”*
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)

We cannot afford to get our eyes on the circumstances or on the amount of time it is taking for our destiny to come to pass. We must place our confidence in the God who created the destiny and believe He is faithful to perform His Word. Hebrews 10:35-36 (NKJV) *“Do not cast away your confidence, which has great reward. ³⁶For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise.”*

II. INTEGRITY DEVELOPMENT

Genesis 39:1-6 (NKJV) *“Now Joseph had been taken down to Egypt. And Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh, captain of the guard, an Egyptian, bought him from the Ishmaelites who had taken him down there. ²The*

LORD was with Joseph, and he was a successful man; and he was in the house of his master the Egyptian.

³And his master saw that the LORD was with him and that the LORD made all he did to prosper in his hand.

⁴So Joseph found favor in his sight, and served him. Then he made him overseer of his house, and all that he had he put under his authority. ⁵So it was, from the time that he had made him overseer of his house and all that he had, that the LORD blessed the Egyptian's house for Joseph's sake; and the blessing of the LORD was on all that he had in the house and in the field. ⁶Thus he left all that he had in Joseph's hand, and he did not know what he had except for the bread which he ate. Now Joseph was handsome in form and appearance."

By the age of seventeen or so, Joseph has endured more hardship than most people encounter in a lifetime. Joseph had already faced: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Rejection of his dream
- Rejection of his honesty
- Rejection from his brethren

Rejection brings with it one of the greatest emotional battles one can fight. In the midst of the process of dealing with the rejection of his brothers, Joseph finds himself being sold into slavery to an Egyptian businessman.

Think of this: the dream was given by God and rather than moving toward the pinnacle of success, Joseph is

thrown away by his brothers, left for dead, and twice sold.

This thing is not turning out like Joseph had imagined. I don't think I have ever talked to a successful person who has not had their fair share of pain and rejection.

Joseph settles into life as a slave serving his master Potiphar. As he serves Potiphar, [God begins to bless Potiphar in unusual ways](#). The blessing of God upon Joseph's work catches the attention of Potiphar. Being the good businessman he is, Potiphar slowly begins to give Joseph extra responsibility as well as authority. Joseph garners more responsibility and authority in Potiphar's house than one would think a slave would ordinarily be able to acquire.

What we do with authority and responsibility will be a factor in whether or not we will be able to achieve our destiny. A little authority goes a long way with some people; others view authority as an opportunity to faithfully discharge responsibility. Authority allows for some people to become dictators; others allow authority to hone their leadership skills and actually serve in a more beneficial and effective way.

Integrity serves as a voltage regulator for authority!

Joseph was one of those leaders who exercised wisdom when given authority. As a result, added authority and responsibility pointed out the fact that Joseph not only could be trusted but should be trusted. [George Bernard Shaw](#) said, "*We are made wise not by*

the recollection of our past, but by the responsibility for our future.” (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

In the process of time, Potiphar gives Joseph such responsibility and authority that Joseph is made the Business Manager for Potiphar.

Joseph scored pretty high when confronted with difficulty, but how would he fare in the face of success? As with Joseph, we all face *two very vulnerable moments in one’s life*: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- When we face trials
- When we achieve success

In the midst of the greatest level of success Joseph had known in his short life, he was about to be confronted with the greatest test to date. This test would be a test of his integrity. *Abraham Lincoln* said **(PLACE THIS QUOTE ON THE SCREEN FIRST THEN ADD THE NEXT QUOTE TO IT)**, *“Nearly all men can stand adversity, but if you want to test a man's character, give him power.”* *Warren Buffet* said, *“In looking for people to hire, you look for three qualities: integrity, intelligence, and energy. And if they don't have the first, the other two will kill you.”* **(LEAVE BOTH QUOTES ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

Integrity and character are essential cornerstones which one should build any success upon. One cannot

succeed over the long haul if this bedrock ingredient is missing from one's life.

Joseph was a young, virile man who was already fighting against the demands of testosterone when the wife of Potiphar begins an onslaught of seduction in relation to Joseph. She subjects him to this overwhelming attempt to get him to commit an immoral act with her day after day.

Joseph allows his integrity to be developed by continuing to reject the untoward advances of Mrs. Potiphar. Aristotle said, *"Men acquire a particular quality by constantly acting in a particular way."*

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

This is exactly what Joseph did, day after day; he acted with integrity until he became a man of integrity!

A person does not become known as a person of integrity by making one good decision. Integrity often involves a lifetime of good choices. On the other hand, one can work a lifetime to build a reputation of character and integrity only to throw it all away with one bad decision. Tyron Edwards said, *"Thoughts lead on to purposes; purposes go forth in action; actions form habits; habits decide character; and character fixes our destiny."* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

Joseph rejects the sexual advances of Mrs. Potiphar and even goes so far as to completely avoid being in her presence. Genesis 39:6-9 (CEV) *"Joseph was well-built and handsome, ⁷ and Potiphar's wife soon*

noticed him. She asked him to make love to her,⁸ but he refused and said, “My master isn’t worried about anything in his house, because he has placed me in charge of everything he owns.⁹ No one in my master’s house is more important than I am. The only thing he hasn’t given me is you, and that’s because you are his wife. I won’t sin against God by doing such a terrible thing as this.”¹⁰ She kept begging Joseph day after day, but he refused to do what she wanted or even to go near her.” Joseph used wisdom on at least two levels here: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He recognized the temptation for what it was, a sin against his God as well as a sin against his master. Joseph was in a foreign country! Who would know? He would know and God would know! The conscience is the moral policeman in our lives, we must never override it!
- He stayed as far from Mrs. Potiphar as possible! Joseph realized his integrity and destiny were at stake and he vowed not to do anything harmful to either one!

Joseph was determined to live by a certain code of ethics even when no-one was looking! Harry Truman said, *“A person who is fundamentally honest doesn't need a code of ethics. The Ten Commandments and the Sermon on the Mount are all the ethical code anybody needs.”* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

One day while Potiphar was away, this immoral woman attempts to force Joseph to commit adultery

with her. When he rejects her advances, she rips his coat from him, lays it beside her on the bed, and cries rape! Joseph is trapped in a hopeless situation. Though he is the Business Manager for Potiphar, he is also a slave from another country. There would be no hearing, no trial, no jury, and no mercy. He is sentenced to an Egyptian prison.

When Joseph became the Business Manager of Potiphar he no doubt thought he could see the light at the end of the tunnel, only to discover it was an oncoming train! Just when he could begin to put the pieces of his dream together he finds himself hopelessly trapped in an Egyptian prison! Benjamin Franklin once said, *"Let no pleasure tempt thee, no profit allure thee, no persuasion move thee, to do anything which thou knowest to be evil; so shalt thou always live in jollity; for a good conscience is a continual Christmas."* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

Joseph had resisted temptation and it seemed his reward would be a lifetime confined to a prison in Egypt! The feelings Joseph experienced are not too different from ours when we seem to be getting it altogether and all of a sudden we experience an onslaught of reversals.

Think of this, in one terrible night Joseph went from Business Manager for one of the richest, most popular men in all of Egypt to being a prisoner, but he **never surrendered his integrity or his dream.** **(ADD NEXT SLIDE TO THIS SLIDE THEN LEAVE BOTH**

ON THE SCREEN UNTIL END OF THE SERVICE)

Whatever we do, **we should never give up our integrity or our dream!** Look at what Paul had to say on this subject. Acts 20:22-24 (NKJV) ***“I go bound in the spirit to Jerusalem, not knowing the things that will happen to me there, ²³“except that the Holy Spirit testifies in every city, saying that chains and tribulations await me. ²⁴“But none of these things move me; nor do I count my life dear to myself, so that I may finish my race with joy, and the ministry which I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God.”***

It is easy to talk about becoming a person of integrity, but this involves a lifetime of good decisions and taking the high road in every situation.

III. DEDICATION OF A SERVANTS HEART

Genesis 39:20 (NKJV) ***“Then Joseph’s master took him and put him into the prison, a place where the king’s prisoners were confined. And he was there in the prison.”***

Some would say Joseph had developed a servant’s heart during his tenure in the house of Potiphar and I would agree the process probably began there. However; in Potiphar’s house, though Joseph was a slave, he did have some liberties and was somewhat compensated. (While interviewing a potential staff member some years ago I asked them if they were accustomed to being paid weekly because we issue

checks bi-monthly. The response was “*Yes I am accustomed to being paid weakly, very weakly!*”)

In **prison**, Joseph had no liberties and was not compensated at all. This **is where the real Joseph would come to light and be discovered.** **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

The real question here is whether he could dedicate his heart to servant-hood when all things were against him. Could he be confined to prison and preserve a good attitude?

The last time I checked, prison is not the most comfortable place in the world. Most criminals are not sorry for what they did, they are sorry they got caught. Their sorrow does not center around what they did wrong, but on the loss of freedom.

Years ago I heard a guy say, “*I’d rather be in church than to be in the best prison in America!*” I would rather be in church than the best:

- Prison
- Hospital
- Doctor’s office
- Country club
- Luxury hotel

I would rather be in the presence of the Lord and around God’s people than any place I can think of.

Joseph has now suffered: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Rejection of his dream
- Rejection of his honesty
- Rejection from his brethren
- Rejection as a result of being falsely accused
- Rejection from his employer

Just when he is beginning to feel that life may turn out as he had dreamed – wham! His legs have been cut out from under him, once again. It must have seemed like one step forward and two steps backward.

Have you ever felt that way?

- In your educational process
- In your profession
- In your marriage
- In your parenting
- In your finances

I am quite sure all of us have been there at some level or another.

Joseph probably thought of quitting, but his dream kept him from doing something which would dumb-down his destiny. Joseph is in a crucial time, would he be able to maintain his dream from prison?

Will we be able to maintain our dream when it seems all things are against us? This is such a critical time. What happens during this time frame will become the measuring stick of later success.

Listen to what the Bible has to say about Joseph's incarceration. [Genesis 39:20](#) (NKJV) ***"Then Joseph's master took him and put him into the prison, a place where the king's prisoners were confined. And he was there in the prison."*** That's it. A couple of

sentences. He was in prison, end of the story, right? Wrong! I am not sure how long Joseph was in prison before the warden recognized Joseph's gifts, but Joseph's attitude, work ethic, and integrity eventually attracted the attention of the warden. When we are in a difficult place, we should continue allowing the Holy Spirit to empower us. If we do this, eventually things will begin to turn for us. [Psalms 37:4-25](#) (NKJV)

"The steps of a good man are ordered by the LORD,

And He delights in his way. ²⁴Though he fall, he shall not be utterly cast down; For the LORD upholds him with His hand." [Jeremiah 29:11-](#)

[14](#) (NKJV) ***"I know the plans I have for you,"***

says the LORD. "They are plans for good and

not for disaster, to give you a future and a

hope. ¹² In those days when you pray, I will

listen. ¹³ If you look for me in earnest, you will

find me when you seek me. ¹⁴ I will be found by

you," says the LORD. "I will end your captivity

and restore your fortunes. I will gather you out

of the nations where I sent you and bring you

home again to your own land." [2 Timothy 1:7-](#)

[9](#) (KJV) ***"God hath not given us the spirit of***

fear; but of power, and of love, and of a sound

mind. ⁸ Be not thou therefore ashamed of the

testimony of our Lord, nor of me his prisoner:

but be thou partaker of the afflictions of the

gospel according to the power of God; ⁹ Who

hath saved us, and called us with an holy calling, not according to our works, but according to his own purpose and grace, which was given us in Christ Jesus before the world began.”

Think of it: Joseph the dreamer in an Egyptian prison! But wait a minute – that’s not the end of the story!

[Genesis 39:21-23](#) (NKJV) “*But the LORD was with Joseph and showed him mercy, and He gave him favor in the sight of the keeper of the prison.* ²²*And the keeper of the prison committed to Joseph’s hand all the prisoners who were in the prison; whatever they did there, it was his doing.* ²³*The keeper of the prison did not look into anything that was under Joseph’s authority, because the LORD was with him; and whatever he did, the LORD made it prosper.*”

[Genesis 40:1-19](#) (NKJV) “*It came to pass after these things that the butler and the baker of the king of Egypt offended their lord, the king of Egypt.* ²*And Pharaoh was angry with his two officers, the chief butler and the chief baker.* ³*So he put them in custody in the house of the captain of the guard, in the prison, the place where Joseph was confined.* ⁴*And the captain of the guard charged Joseph with them, and he served them; so they were in custody for a while.* ⁵*Then the butler and the baker of the king of Egypt, who were confined in the prison, had a dream, both of them, each man’s dream in one night and each man’s dream with its own interpretation.* ⁶*And Joseph came in to them in the morning and looked at them, and saw that they were sad.* ⁷*So he asked Pharaoh’s officers who were with him in the custody*

of his lord's house, saying, "Why do you look so sad today?" ⁸And they said to him, "We each have had a dream, and there is no interpreter of it." So Joseph said to them, "Do not interpretations belong to God? Tell them to me, please." ⁹Then the chief butler told his dream to Joseph, and said to him, "Behold, in my dream a vine was before me, ¹⁰"and in the vine were three branches; it was as though it budded, its blossoms shot forth, and its clusters brought forth ripe grapes. ¹¹"Then Pharaoh's cup was in my hand; and I took the grapes and pressed them into Pharaoh's cup, and placed the cup in Pharaoh's hand." ¹²And Joseph said to him, "This is the interpretation of it: The three branches are three days." ¹³"Now within three days Pharaoh will lift up your head and restore you to your place, and you will put Pharaoh's cup in his hand according to the former manner, when you were his butler. ¹⁴"But remember me when it is well with you, and please show kindness to me; make mention of me to Pharaoh, and get me out of this house. ¹⁵"For indeed I was stolen away from the land of the Hebrews; and also I have done nothing here that they should put me into the dungeon." ¹⁶When the chief baker saw that the interpretation was good, he said to Joseph, "I also was in my dream, and there were three white baskets on my head. ¹⁷"In the uppermost basket were all kinds of baked goods for Pharaoh, and the birds ate them out of the basket on my head." ¹⁸So Joseph answered and said, "This is the interpretation of it: The three baskets are three days." ¹⁹"Within three days Pharaoh will lift off your head from you and hang

you on a tree; and the birds will eat your flesh from you.”

While in prison, several things happened to Joseph:

(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The Lord was with him
- The Lord showed him mercy
- The Lord gave him favor
- The Lord prospered his work
- The Lord gave him a ministry (To the butler and baker, as well as the warden and the other staff and inmates)

Our way may become difficult from time to time, but the Lord will do the same for us in perplexing times as He did for Joseph so long ago:

- The Lord will be with us.
- The Lord will show us mercy.
- The Lord will give us favor.
- The Lord will prosper our work.
- The Lord will give us a ministry.

We must remember, as the Lord was with Joseph in the darkest chapter of his life, He will be with us. [Psalms 125:1-2](#) (KJV) ***“They that trust in the LORD shall be as mount Zion, which cannot be removed, but abideth for ever.***

²As the mountains are round about Jerusalem, so the LORD is round about his people from henceforth even for ever.” [Psalms 30:5](#)

(NKJV) ***“Weeping may endure for a night, But joy comes in the morning.”*** [Malachi 3:3](#)

(NKJV) *“He will sit as a refiner and a purifier of silver; He will purify the sons of Levi, And purge them as gold and silver, That they may offer to the LORD An offering in righteousness.”*

Why would God allow a man of integrity, such as Joseph, go to prison? **(LEAVE ON**

SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) Psalms

105:17-22 (NKJV) *“He (GOD) sent a man before them— Joseph—who was sold as a slave. ¹⁸They hurt his feet with fetters, He was laid in irons. ¹⁹Until the time that his word came to pass, the word of the LORD tested him. ²⁰The king sent and released him, the ruler of the people let him go free. ²¹He made him lord of his house, And ruler of all his possessions, ²²To bind his princes at his pleasure, And teach his elders wisdom.”* We must remember, there is always a rhyme and reason beyond the madness.

Why does God allow certain things to occur in our lives? He is allowing us to dedicate our heart to servant-hood! **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- There's no victory without a fight!
- There's no sunrise without a night!
- There's no purchase without a cost!
- There's no Crown without a Cross!

Where Joseph was going it would be imperative for him to be able to model servant leadership!

In Joseph's prison cell, God was designing a man who would model servant leadership while being the Prime Minister of Egypt! The time spent in prison may have felt like a waste of time to Joseph, but it was some of the most productive time of his life!

We go through things so our hearts can become dedicated to servant-hood. Albert Schweitzer said, *"I don't know what your destiny will be, but one thing I do know; the only ones among you who will be really happy are those who have sought and found how to serve."* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** Jesus said, Matthew 23:11-12 (NKJV) ***"But he who is greatest among you shall be your servant. ¹²"And whoever exalts himself will be humbled, and he who humbles himself will be exalted."***

Joseph was such a servant that he became an assistant to the warden! He was so trustworthy that when he was given an assignment, his superiors never had to check on him to make sure he had followed through. Genesis 39:23 (NKJV) ***"The keeper of the prison did not look into anything that was under Joseph's authority, because the LORD was with him; and whatever he did, the LORD made it prosper."***

It's not what you expect that makes the difference, it's what you inspect!

A heart dedicated to servant-hood belongs to a person who can be trusted with: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Vast authority
- Immense assets
- Enormous responsibility
- Tremendous human resources

When we are walking through the difficulties of this life we should attempt to match Joseph step for step: maintaining our integrity, keeping a good attitude, and developing a servant leader's heart to the point that we do our best work under pressure!

IV. DOING THE DREAM

Genesis 41:37-44 (NKJV) *"So the advice was good in the eyes of Pharaoh and in the eyes of all his servants. ³⁸And Pharaoh said to his servants, "Can we find such a one as this, a man in whom is the Spirit of God?" ³⁹Then Pharaoh said to Joseph, "Inasmuch as God has shown you all this, there is no one as discerning and wise as you. ⁴⁰"You shall be over my house, and all my people shall be ruled according to your word; only in regard to the throne will I be greater than you." ⁴¹And Pharaoh said to Joseph, "See, I have set you over all the land of Egypt." ⁴²Then Pharaoh took his signet ring off his hand and put it on Joseph's hand; and he clothed him in garments of fine linen and put a gold chain around his neck. ⁴³And he had him ride in the second chariot which he had; and they cried out before him, "Bow the knee!" So he set him over all the land of Egypt. ⁴⁴Pharaoh also said to Joseph, "I am Pharaoh,*

and without your consent no man may lift his hand or foot in all the land of Egypt.”

Joseph is now 30 years old, thirteen years have transpired between the time he was sold into Egyptian slavery and the time he stood before the King to become the Prime Minister of Egypt. Think of it, thirteen years in Potiphar’s house and the prison! This has not been an easy road; in fact it has been an unusually difficult path to travel. Joseph has now suffered: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Rejection of his dream
- Rejection of his honesty
- Rejection from his brethren
- Rejection as a result of being falsely accused
- Rejection from his employer
- Several years of false imprisonment

During Joseph’s time in prison, the butler and baker of the king were incarcerated. Some time later, both the butler and baker dreamed dreams and Joseph interpreted their dreams with the stipulation that when the butler returned to the palace he would tell Pharaoh of Joseph’s false imprisonment.

Just as Joseph predicted, the butler was restored to the king’s favor and the baker was hanged. (He must have been a really bad cook!)

When the butler was restored to the king’s favor, Joseph must have nervously awaited the call of the warden for Joseph to meet with the king. He probably anxiously anticipated the meeting with the king so he

could plead his case and once-and-for-all prove his innocence.

Minutes turned into hours, hours turned into days, days turned into weeks, weeks turned into months, months turned into years – two years to be exact. Joseph must have felt that his life would never be disconnected from the emotional roller coaster he seemed to be hopelessly trapped on.

After two years, Pharaoh dreams a dream which neither he nor his spiritual advisers could interpret. The butler remembers Joseph and the King calls for him. Joseph tells the king there will be seven years of bumper crops in Egypt followed by seven years of famine. Joseph advises the King to store grain and food in the seven years of plenty so that the Kingdom could be sustained during the seven years of famine.

Pharaoh agrees with the interpretation and makes Joseph the Prime Minister. Joseph is there. He has arrived. He finally made it. He is now doing the dream!

God almost never works within our time frame. We cannot afford to attempt to squeeze God into our time restraint but patiently await His timing!

Think of others who found themselves awaiting the promise of God: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Moses** was eighty when he became the Senior Pastor of First Assembly of God in the Wilderness
- **Caleb** was eighty-five when he was given permission to conquer his inheritance within Canaan
- **Abraham** was one-hundred and Sara was ninety when she gave birth to the promised son

So we want to do the dream? How patient are we? Are we willing to wait through the development stage? If God allowed us to step into our destiny prematurely we would mess up the set-up! **Winston Churchill** said, *“It is a mistake to look too far ahead. Only one link in the chain of destiny can be handled at a time.”*

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

Joseph survived thirty years of dashed dreams to finally stand on the pinnacle of his destiny. If we had set out to write a novel that allowed for Joseph's success, none of us would have had the creativity to map out such a path. The path of Joseph is marked by high drama. The important thing is that he maintained his dream while not sacrificing his integrity to climb the ladder of success.

What good is success if we sacrifice our integrity and character to get there? **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** Some of God's people have grown a ministry that was bigger than their character and they have embarrassed themselves and reeked havoc on the Kingdom of God!

When we force doors open, we move beyond the perimeters of our character, nothing good can come out of such a thing. We must learn to wait upon God! Psalms 25:5 (NKJV) ***“Lead me in Your truth and teach me, For You are the God of my salvation; On You I wait all the day.”*** Psalms 25:21 (NKJV) ***“Let integrity and uprightness preserve me, For I wait for You.”*** Isaiah 40:28-31 (NKJV) ***“The everlasting God, the LORD, The Creator of the ends of the earth, Neither faints nor is weary. His understanding is unsearchable. ²⁹ He gives power to the weak, And to those who have no might He increases d strength. ³⁰ Even the youths shall faint and be weary, And the young men shall utterly fall, ³¹ But those who wait on the LORD Shall renew their strength; They shall mount up with wings like eagles, They shall run and not be weary, They shall walk and not faint.”***

If Joseph had gone directly from his father's house to Prime Minister he would have crashed and burned, but he had time to:

- Dream the dream
- Develop his integrity
- Develop a servant's heart

Joseph woke up one morning a prisoner and went to bed the Prime Minister!

When Joseph became Prime Minister, he was mature enough to understand that his steps were being ordered of God rather than a result of his own ability.

Because he knew that being afforded the opportunity to do the dream was about what God wanted to use him to do for others, rather than a plan for his own comfort, **Joseph: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Did not retaliate against Mr. or Mrs. Potiphar who sent him to prison through a false charge
- Did not take revenge against the butler who added two difficult years to his prison term
- Did not even the score with his brothers when they came to Egypt to buy corn during the seven years of famine

When his identity was revealed to his brothers, notice how Joseph deals with the uncomfortable situation.

Genesis 45:3-8 (NKJV) ***“Then Joseph said to his brothers, “I am Joseph; does my father still live?” But his brothers could not answer him, for they were dismayed in his presence. ⁴And Joseph said to his brothers, “Please come near to me.” So they came near. Then he said: “I am Joseph your brother, whom you sold into Egypt. ⁵“But now, do not therefore be grieved or angry with yourselves because you sold me here; for God sent me before you to preserve life. ⁶“For these two years the famine has been in the land, and there are still five years in which there will be neither plowing nor harvesting. ⁷“And God sent me before you to preserve a posterity for you in the earth, and to save your lives by a great deliverance. ⁸“So now it was not you who sent me here, but God; and He has made me a father to***

Pharaoh, and lord of all his house, and a ruler throughout all the land of Egypt.”

Joseph had a pretty good head on his shoulders for a thirty-nine year old Prime Minister. He was mature beyond his years because of the training camp God had allowed him to walk through.

CONCLUSION:

This world is speeding down the fast lane in search of success. Some folks will do anything to achieve it.

Mahatma Gandhi said, *"There are seven things that will destroy us: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME, THEN LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)*

- *“Wealth without work”*
- *“Pleasure without conscience”*
- *“Knowledge without character”*
- *“Religion without sacrifice”*
- *“Politics without principle”*
- *“Science without humanity”*
- *“Business without ethics”*

As believers, we must make sure we attain whatever level of success we are blessed to achieve, God’s way!

In God’s world, the process is as important as doing the dream. It really is about the process because the course is a part of the destination!

